

William J. Kezerian

Curriculum Vitae

Department of Linguistics
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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Broad Syntax, French-based Creoles, computational linguistics, fieldwork, and bilingualism.
Narrow Language contact, Guadeloupean Creole, NLP, complementation, reduplicative focus
fronting, and experimental methods.

EDUCATION

2026- **PhD, Linguistics**, University of Pennsylvania
2025-2026 **MA, Linguistic Studies**, Syracuse University
Concentration in NLP
Thesis: Complementation in Guadeloupean Creole: An Experimental and Computational
Account. *Supervisor: Jaklin Kornfilt*
2021-2024 **BA, Linguistics, Comparative Literature**, University of Massachusetts Amherst
Summa Cum Laude; Minor in French and Francophone Studies
2023 Certificate in TESOL

Summer Schools, Exchanges

2025 VII International Summer School Language Policy and Language Planning, The University
for Foreigners of Siena, Siena, Italy
2025 NASSLLI, the University of Washington, Seattle, Washington
2024 ESSLLI, KU Leuven, Leuven, Belgium
2019 Lycée Dumont d'Urville - LaPlace, Caen, France
Exchange student; TA in Intermediate English

PUBLICATIONS

Chapters in Edited Volumes

in revision **Kezerian, W.**¹, Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. (in revision). *Focus and
fronting in Guadeloupean Creole: The role of complementation in focus*. O. Duplâtre & P.-
Y. Modicom (Eds.), *Issues in the formal and functional typology of focus*. John Benjamins.

Peer-Reviewed Conference Proceedings

2024 **Kezerian, W.**¹, Wyner, L. A., Ansari, S., & Yu, K. M. "Ye Olde French: Effect of Old
and Middle French on SIGMORPHON-UniMorph Shared Task Data." In *Proceedings of the
21st SIGMORPHON Workshop on Computational Research in Phonetics, Phonology, and
Morphology* (pp. 39–50), Mexico City, Mexico. Association for Computational Linguistics.
[LINK](#)

Edited Volumes

2023 Nguyen, K., **Kezerian, W.**, Weaver, S., & Iwanicki, L. (Eds.). (2023). *mOthertongue
2023 (Full Issue)*. mOthertongue, 28(1). Comparative Literature Program, University of
Massachusetts Amherst.

¹First author

PEER-REVIEWED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- 2026 **Kezerian, W.**, Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. “Complementizer *kè* Variation in Guadeloupean Creole: Experimental Judgments and Spontaneous Speech.” To be presented at the 17th International Colloquium of Creole Studies, Schoelcher, Martinique..
- 2026 **Kezerian, W.**, Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. “Relative Attachment: Long-distance PP adjunct attachment in Guadeloupean Creole.” Presented at the *Society for Pidgin and Creole Linguistics Winter Meeting 2026*, in conjunction with the *LSA 2026 Winter Meeting*, New Orleans, USA.
- 2025a. **Kezerian, W.**, Tselioudis, V., Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. “The Role of *kè* in Guadeloupean Creole Complementation: A comparative syntactic analysis.” Presented at *Syntax of the World’s Languages X*, University of Potsdam, Potsdam, Germany.
- 2025b. **Kezerian, W.**, Tselioudis, V., Jeannot-Fourcaud, B., Barrière, I., & Govain, R. “Focus and Fronting in Guadeloupean Creole: Examining the role of complementation in focus.” Presented at the *SLE 2025 Workshop: Issues in the formal and functional typology of focus*, Université Bordeaux Montaigne, Bordeaux, France.
- 2024 **Kezerian, W.**, Wyner, L. A., Ansari, S., & Yu, K. M. “Ye Olde French: Effect of Old and Middle French on SIGMORPHON-UniMorph Shared Task Data.” Presented at the *SIGMORPHON Workshop, ACL 2024*, Mexico City, Mexico.

INVITED TALKS

2026. “Complementation in Guadeloupean Creole: An Experimental and Computational Account.” Presented at the *4th Annual Linguistic Studies Research and Creative Scholarship Fest*, Syracuse University, NY.
- 2025a. “Testing Clause Boundaries: Focus and Complementation in Guadeloupean Creole.” Presented to *The Research Group on Creole Grammars (GRGC)*, Structures Formelles du Langage, Université Paris 8, France.
- 2025b. “Creole for the Classroom: Linguistic documentation and NLP in empowering native-language education in Guadeloupe.” Presented at the *VII International Summer School Language Policy and Language Planning: Bilingual minds and translingual practices in multicultural contexts*, The University for Foreigners of Siena, Italy.
- 2025c. “NLP in Language Documentation: A case study on Guadeloupean Creole focus and fronting.” Presented at the *Linguistic Studies Program Research and Creative Scholarship Fest*, Syracuse University, NY.
- 2025d. “Linguistic interaction in Guadeloupean Creole oral histories: Call and response to facilitate the tradition’s survival.” Presented at the *French Graduate Colloquium*, Syracuse University, NY.
- 2024 “Subordinate clauses in Guadeloupean Creole: Complementizer dropping, NP/VP focus, and PP focus attachment.” Presented at the *NSF-IRES Conference*, University of the Antilles, Pointe-à-Pitre, Guadeloupe.

RESEARCH

Master’s Thesis

- Current **Complementation in Guadeloupean Creole: An Experimental and Computational Account.**
Developing an ASR model for Guadeloupean Creole using field-collected speech data to aid language documentation and analysis of syntactic features such as focus and complementation. Integrating NLP with field linguistics to address data processing bottlenecks and promote language technology access for speakers of understudied languages. *Supervised by Jaklin Kornfilt.*

NSF Research Fellowship

- 2024 **Focus Constructions, Complementizer Dropping, and Definite Clause Deixis within Subordinate Clauses in Guadeloupean Creole.**
Field research documenting syntactic phenomena in Guadeloupean Creole. Combined expertise in computational linguistics and syntactic theory to create three experiments, evaluating speaker intuitions and eliciting complex constructions. (NSF Award No. 1952501)
Supervised by Isabelle Barrière, Béatrice Jeannot-Fourcaud, and Renauld Govain. [LINK](#)

Relevant Graduate Projects

- 2025 **Referent Tracking and Nonbinary “They” in Apparent Time: Age Effects and the Role of Gender Cues.**
Designed a psycholinguistic storyboard narration task examining referent tracking strategies with nonbinary they. I reveal a generational gap in usage, with older speakers producing more errors and greater reliance on pronoun avoidance strategies.
- 2025 **NLP methods for low-resource language documentation: A case study on Guadeloupean Creole.**
Developed a custom grapheme-to-phoneme (G2P) model for Guadeloupean Creole to evaluate NLP methods for low-resource language documentation, achieving a 2.8% Phoneme Error Rate—significantly outperforming pre-trained models.
- 2024 **The Passives were Analyzed: Comparing model performance in classifying passive use in news headline bias.**
Fine-tuned BERT and ChatGPT models to classify media bias in headlines about the 2004 Israel-Palestine conflict, focusing on passive voice and agent omission. Achieved 89% accuracy with fine-tuned ChatGPT, outperforming baseline heuristics and LLMs.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- 2025-2026 **Instructor of Record**, FRENCH 102, Syracuse University
- 2025 **Instructor of Record**, FRENCH 201, Syracuse University
- 2023-2024 **Instructor**, Advanced American Culture and English Language, UMass Amherst
- 2022-2023 **Instructor**, Intermediate American Culture and English Language, UMass Amherst
- 2022-2024 **ESL Tutor**, UMass Amherst ESL Program
- 2019 **EFL Teaching Assistant**, Lycée Dumont d’Urville, Laplace, Caen, France

EMPLOYMENT

- Current **Teaching Assistantship**, French and Francophone Program, Syracuse University
- 2024-2025 **NSF-IRES Research Fellow - Experimental Linguistics in the Caribbean**, University of the Antilles, Guadeloupe [LINK](#)
- 2022-2024 **Teaching Internship**, ESL Program, UMass Amherst
- 2023-2024 **French Translator**, UMass Daily Collegian
- 2023 **Multilingual Editor**, mOthertongue Journal of the Arts, UMass Amherst
- 2023 **French Translator**, the International Rescue Committee

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- 2024 **ToBI Prosody Course**, MIT
- 2023 **Programming for Everybody (Python)**, University of Michigan
- 2023 **Data structures (Python)**, University of Michigan

AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

2026	The Milkatu Garba Memorial Award for Field Linguistics, Syracuse University
2025	Professional, Academic, and Creative (PAC) Work Grant, Syracuse University, \$600
2025	CAS-LLL Summer Research Fellowship, Syracuse University, \$375
2024	French Teaching Assistantship, Syracuse University
2024	Tuition Scholarship, Syracuse University
2024	National Science Foundation IRES Fellowship, \$1,500 LINK
2023	Luise Bonner Scholarship Fund, \$1,420
2023	Phi Kappa Phi Honors Society
2022	Alpha Lambda Delta Honors Society

SKILLS AND CERTIFICATIONS

Programming	Python, R, JavaScript, Bash
Technical Skills	L ^A T _E X, Praat, PsychoPy, ToBI
Certifications	CITI Program - IRB/Human Subjects Research (Social & Behavioral)

LANGUAGES

Native	English
Advanced	French
Intermediate	Haitian Creole, Japanese
Fieldwork	Guadeloupean Creole